

Utilitarianism Is Demanding, But Utilitarians Need Not Demand

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1 Moral Prescription and Moral Demanding

Utilitarianism, like many moral theories, is commonly understood as prescribing certain actions as morally obligatory. In classical act utilitarianism, an agent ought to perform the action that maximizes overall utility in a given situation. This prescription is obligatory, regardless of what the relevant action is, and particularly, it is never supererogatory, no matter how demanding it is. This prescription is also normative, stemming directly from the utility maximization principle. The act of demanding that others perform such actions, however, must be distinguished from this prescription.

Moral prescription, in this essay, refers to the evaluative standard set by a moral theory regarding what an agent ought to do. *Moral demanding*, however, refers to the interpersonal or social act of requiring, pressuring, or blaming an agent for failing to meet that standard. The goal of this essay is to argue that these two should not be treated as identical, and that their conflation may actively hinder societal ethical development. When applied to act utilitarianism, we argue that this implicit collapse of moral prescription into moral demanding is one factor of the demandingness objection.

Moral demanding is fundamentally distinguished from moral prescription in that its existence owes to a particular moral agent. Prescription is the application of the moral theory to a particular action or a situation. Prescribing act utilitarianism is applying the utility maximization principle, which should be thought of as a fundamentally logical process. On paper, the prescription should be independent of who is performing the application, as the principle should ideally take every single information about all agents in question. For moral theories grounded in a divine being, such as divine command theory, moral prescription depends on that being. However, insofar as the divine constitutes the standard of morality itself, it is not a moral agent within the theory. In all, moral prescription is theoretically an agent-independent process, with practical disagreements caused by epistemic imperfections of agents.

In contrast, moral demanding is a social action, done from a moral agent to another. Particularly, as an action of a moral agent, moral demanding is itself subject to evaluation according to the moral theory. To suppose otherwise, that moral demanding is exempt from moral evaluation, can have detrimental effects; indeed, even coercive or violent attempts to impose one's moral standards can be understood as forms of moral demanding. The next section applies this statement to act utilitarianism, and explores its consequences with respect to the demandingness objection.

Works Cited

Singer, Peter. "Famine, affluence, and morality." *Applied Ethics*, Routledge, 2017, pp. 132–42.